

GLOCAL FOUNDATION, MICRO-GRANTS PROJECT

Refugees in Canada

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2024/02/02

Introduction

Refugees are individuals who have been forced to flee their country due to war, violence, climate change, or conflict and seek refuge in another nation for their safety. In this research paper, we will be exploring the challenges, benefits, and stories of refugees who seek safety in Canada. This paper aims to raise awareness about the refugee situation and to encourage Canadian youth to be welcoming and accepting towards refugees.

- **Who are the refugees?**

Refugees are people who fled their country due to war, violence, climate change, or conflict and have fled an international border for their safety. The [1951 Refugee Convention](#) is a key legal document and defines a refugee as: “someone unable or unwilling to return to their country of origin owing to a well-founded fear of being persecuted for reasons of race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion. There are over 20 million refugees and 100 million displaced people around the globe, and 75% of them are from countries that all had a war history.

Syrian Arab Republic	6.5 million
Afghanistan	6.1 million
Ukraine	5.9 million

Syria is a country in the Middle East that has been plagued by war and conflict since 2011. The Syrian civil war has led to the displacement of millions of people, with many fleeing to neighboring countries and beyond in search of safety and security. The conflict in Syria has had a major impact on the refugee crisis, with Syrians making up a significant portion of refugees around the world. Many Syrians have sought refuge in Canada, which has been one of the few countries to accept large numbers of Syrian refugees.

Afghanistan is a country in South Asia that has been affected by war and conflict for many years. The ongoing conflict in Afghanistan has led to the displacement of millions of people, with many fleeing to

Neighboring countries and beyond in search of safety and security. Due to the situation in Afghanistan, many Afghans have become refugees, making up a significant portion of refugees around the world. Canada has been one of the few countries to accept large numbers of Afghan refugees, providing them with a new home and opportunities for a better life.

Ukraine is a country in Eastern Europe that has experienced political turmoil and conflict in recent years. The ongoing conflict in Ukraine has led to the displacement of millions of people, with many fleeing to neighboring countries and beyond in search of safety and security. Due to the situation in Ukraine, many Ukrainians have become refugees, making up a significant portion of refugees around the world. Canada has been one of the few countries to accept large numbers of Ukrainian refugees, providing them with a new home and opportunities for a better life.

- **Refugees in Canada**

Canada is one of the few countries that accept refugees from around the globe, Canada is known for its unlimited opportunities for refugees and migrants.

1 Diversity Canada is known for its diversity and multiculturalism, which is why it is a popular destination for refugees and migrants from all over the world. Canada has a long history of welcoming newcomers, and the government and Canadian people have put in place policies and programs to support diversity and inclusion. Canada has an official policy of multiculturalism, which means that the country recognizes and celebrates the diversity of its population and promotes equal opportunities for all. This policy is reflected in many aspects of Canadian society, including its laws, education system, and social programs. As a result, newcomers to Canada can feel welcome and accepted, and they can contribute to Canadian society while retaining their cultural identity.

2 Multiculturalism is another great factor of opportunities in Canada. The fact that every person respects other cultures, beliefs, and opinions, this action gives people who are new to

Canada the kind of confidence they did not have while sharing their own opinions in their own country.

3 Government support can come in many forms such as financial aid, tax breaks, grants, and subsidies. These types of assistance can be crucial to the success of businesses, especially those that are just starting or struggling during challenging economic times. Additionally, government support can also be provided to individuals in the form of social welfare programs, healthcare, and education. These programs help ensure that everyone **Page 3** access to necessities and opportunities for personal and professional growth. There are over 203 organizations in Calgary working for refugees and newcomers (according to a report from Action Dignity).

And even more in the rest of Canada, these organizations help newcomers with things like housing, language barriers, mental health problems, etc.

4 Freedom in Canada is one of the most significant advantages that refugees can enjoy. Canada is a country that values individual rights and freedoms, and newcomers can experience a sense of liberation that they may not have had in their home countries. This freedom includes the freedom of expression, religion, and peaceful assembly. It is a crucial aspect of Canadian society and one that refugees can appreciate as they settle into their new lives in Canada.

Even with these many opportunities, there are still a few main barriers for newcomers such as:

Adapting to a new society can be challenging since most of them don't have the type of freedom in their own country and lots of rules and laws are most likely to be unusual to them.

Language barriers can be a significant challenge for refugees and migrants. Even with the government's support for language learning, more than 70% of newcomers in Canada still struggle to learn English. This can make it difficult for them to communicate, find employment, and integrate into Canadian society. However, there are many organizations and programs available to help newcomers overcome language barriers, including language classes, language exchange programs, and online resources. These resources can help but it will take time and the elders in the communities still might face problems.

Employment struggles Newcomers often face employment struggles in Canada due to a lack of Canadian work experience, language barriers, and discrimination. Finding a job is crucial for newcomers to support themselves and their families, integrate into Canadian society, and contribute to the economy. However, many newcomers find it challenging to find employment in their desired field, which can lead to financial difficulties and social isolation.

Adapting to the weather/climate Adapting to the weather and climate can also be a challenge for refugees who are not used to Canadian weather conditions. Canada is known for its harsh winters, and it can be difficult for refugees who come from warmer climates to adapt to the cold temperatures and snow. However, there are many resources available to help refugees prepare for the weather, such as winter clothing donations and programs that provide information on how to stay warm and safe during the winter months. These resources can help refugees adjust to the Canadian weather and climate, but it can still be a significant challenge for them.

Trauma is specifically for people who have dealt with war and inequality. This affects their way of living. Some might be in constant fear of war and this could affect their mental health a lot.

● **Stories of refugees**

Nadera Giah is an Afghan woman who was a director of women's affairs and is known for her amazing work for the women of Kunduz a province in the northeast of the country says life in Canada is not what she expected it to be, it has been nearly 2 years that she hasn't met any of her family member her large family that is now scattered into different countries this made her go to a state of depression, she says it's hard for her she is relying on government support she can't do any job in here because of her English barriers she has gone to more than 4 or 5 types of different courses and classes of ESL but none of them has affected her English. Nadera Giah is one of the hundreds of women who struggle in Canada.



Sahar Nik/Omari is an Afghan Ukrainian who was born and raised in Ukraine but the cause of the war in Ukraine made her leave Ukraine and seek refuge in Canada. She is 13 years old and in 8th grade. She says her dad owned a large business in Ukraine but here they are struggling a lot. Her mother who owned a salon back in Ukraine is now at home. She speaks Dari and Russian fluently but still struggling a little bit with English though she can understand and speak well. She misses Ukraine where she grew up, she says the places they used to live are probably destroyed by now, she says she is traumatized by the experience of the war and would not wish that upon anyone.

Roya Afshar is an Afghan security officer who used to be a doctor back in Afghanistan. She is one of the few people in the Afghan community who decided to change their careers for this reason. I think she has had an amazing journey of her life in Canada.

Wazhma Shekib: Wazhma Shekib is a compassionate advocate and dedicated professional, driven by a lifelong commitment to championing people's rights. Raised in a family deeply rooted in the pursuit of justice, Wazhma's journey has been marked by resilience and an unwavering dedication to making a positive impact.

Having earned her bachelor's degree from a prestigious university in India, Wazhma's activism reached its pinnacle during her years in Afghanistan. However, the takeover by the Taliban forced her into exile, finding solace in India and Turkey for over a year and a half, away from her cherished family. Despite the challenges, her tenacity prevailed, and she was joyfully reunited with her mother and three siblings upon arriving in Canada. Upon settling in Calgary,

Wazhma swiftly prioritized reuniting her family, successfully bringing her father and younger brother to Canada on November 15th. Her resilience and commitment to her family mirror her dedication to helping others within the Afghan community in Calgary.

Wazhma has seamlessly integrated herself into the fabric of Canadian society, embodying the true spirit of a newcomer success story. Her altruistic endeavors include assisting individuals in completing essential forms, providing ESL classes, and actively volunteering with various organizations to support those in need. Beyond her humanitarian efforts, Wazhma has made significant strides in the business realm by establishing a thriving eye spy business in Calgary. Her entrepreneurial success underscores her ability to excel in diverse fields, showcasing her multifaceted talents and determination. Wazhma Shekib is not only a beloved figure within the Afghan community in Calgary but also a shining example of resilience, compassion, and success in the face of adversity. Canada is fortunate to have such a dedicated and accomplished newcomer contributing to the rich tapestry of its society.



Rabia Shekib: Rabia Shekib, a prominent figure within the Hazara community, has earned widespread recognition for her unwavering commitment to defending and advocating for the rights of the Hazara people. The Shekib family, esteemed not only among the Hazaras but also within other tribes, has played a pivotal role in championing the cause of their community. However, when the Taliban emerged, Rabia Shekib faced a crucial decision for the safety of her family. In a poignant turn of events, her family was forced to scatter, with Rabia and her two sons finding refuge in Albania, her eldest daughter, Wazhma Shekib, in Turkey/India, her

husband and youngest son remaining in Afghanistan, and her youngest daughter seeking asylum in the US with her aunt.

The ensuing two years were marked by the agonizing separation of the Shekib family, a period during which they navigated the complexities of being dispersed across different countries. Despite the challenges, Rabia Shekib and her family managed to reunite in Canada. Their resilience in the face of adversity serves as a testament to the strength of their familial bonds. Currently residing in Canada, the Shekib family continues to extend their support to Hazara newcomers, embodying a spirit of solidarity and community service. Rabia Shekib's enduring commitment to the well-being and rights of the Hazara people remains an inspiration, and their journey reflects the resilience and determination of those who seek a better life in the face of adversity.



Fazila Azimi: fazila is a woman who is suffering so much just like most people in here her family is scattered into different countries her and 3 daughters being with her in canada and the rest of her family including her grandchildren and her husband are all left in turkey she says being without a male dominant it's really hard from them they still rely on government support since neither her or her daughters know any english so they get a job they're all focusing on improving their ESL skills.



Parisa Jamal: she used to be a hair stylist back in turkey but here because of her language barriers she can't get a job to help out her mother. They rely on government support and she is now studying ESL at Bow Valley College here in calgary.



Madina Jamal: Madina Jamal's story reflects the challenges that many refugees face when relocating to a new country. The language barrier can be a significant obstacle to integration, especially for education and employment. It's commendable that Madina and her family are working on improving their English language skills through ESL (English as a Second Language) programs. Given that Madina is enrolled in grade 9 and is facing language barriers, it's essential for her to receive additional support and resources to catch up academically. Schools often provide extra assistance for students with language challenges, such as language support

classes or tutoring. In terms of her family's reliance on government support, it's a common situation for newly arrived refugees. Many countries have support systems in place to help refugees with their basic needs until they can become more self-sufficient. Madina's family may also benefit from community resources, such as local refugee support organizations or cultural integration programs. As her family's immigration cases are ongoing, it's important for them to stay informed about the progress and any required steps. Legal assistance or advice from immigration support services can be valuable during this time. In the long term, as Madina continues her education, it will open up more opportunities for her and increase her chances of overcoming the challenges her family currently faces. It's also crucial for the family to stay connected with the local community, as social support can play a significant role in the integration process. Madina's story underscores the importance of empathy, understanding, and community support for refugees as they navigate the complex process of resettlement and adaptation to a new culture.



Hanifa Omar: a dedicated advocate for gender equality, played a pivotal role in promoting inclusivity within a prominent office in Takhar, a province situated in the northeast of Afghanistan. Unfortunately, with the Taliban assuming control, she found herself compelled to leave her homeland, seeking refuge in Albania for approximately six months before resettling in Canada. Her journey, emblematic of the challenges faced by many Afghan immigrants, highlights the importance of facilitating professional opportunities for those who bring valuable skills and experiences to their new home. Despite her husband's background as a skilled surgeon in Afghanistan, the current circumstances have led him to work in a different capacity, delivering pizzas—a reality they never envisioned. Ms. Hanifa Omar underscores a prevalent concern among

newcomers—a pool of talented individuals grappling with underemployment due to the lack of suitable job opportunities. These individuals possess the knowledge and expertise vital to contributing meaningfully to Canadian society, but they encounter barriers hindering their professional integration.

In light of this, Ms. Hanifa Omar advocates for a proactive role on the part of the government in creating avenues for employment. She believes that harnessing the skills of newcomers not only fosters their integration but also allows them to actively contribute to the growth and prosperity of Canada. Her plea resonates with the broader sentiment shared by many newcomers who seek not merely refuge but an opportunity to thrive professionally and serve their adopted country. Ms. Hanifa Omar's call for a strategic approach to employment opportunities aligns with the vision of a diverse and skilled workforce contributing to Canada's success.



Nooria Hamasa: Nooria Hamasa, an accomplished professional with a robust background in journalism, served as the lead director at one of Afghanistan's foremost radio-television stations, RTA, situated in the northern province of Juzjan. Recognized for her dynamic and active contributions within the media industry, Nooria has exhibited exceptional leadership in her role. After a six-month sojourn in Albania, Nooria Hamasa made the strategic decision to relocate to Canada, specifically choosing Calgary for its promising opportunities.

Over the course of nearly two years, her dedication and perseverance led to a heartwarming reunion with her daughters, who subsequently joined her in Canada. Despite this joyous reunion, Nooria continues to demonstrate unwavering commitment to overcoming the remaining geographical separation from one of her daughters.

In her pursuit of family unity, Nooria Hamasa exemplifies resilience and determination, embodying a spirit that extends beyond professional achievements. Her story serves as a testament to the challenges faced and overcome by individuals seeking a better life, and her ongoing efforts to reunite her family reflect a profound commitment to the values of love, perseverance, and the pursuit of a brighter future.



Hanisa Safi Sadaat: Renowned for her unwavering commitment to advancing women's rights, she stands as one of the eldest members within the community, embodying resilience and dedication. Having actively contributed to the cause of gender equality and tirelessly opposed injustice during her tenure in Afghanistan, she has left an indelible mark on the pursuit of fairness.

Currently residing in the United States, her frequent visits are marked by a continued commitment to her advocacy. Beyond being an advocate, she holds the esteemed position of a respected member within the Afghan community. Her influence extends beyond borders, as her daughters and sons, beneficiaries of her principles, now reside in the U.S. Her story, while emblematic of the challenges faced by women's rights defenders, also serves as a testament to the enduring power of dedication and resilience in the pursuit of justice.



Robina Hamdard: The individual in question, having served as both a UN employee and a women's activist in Afghanistan, faced significant threats to her safety due to her advocacy work. As a result, she sought refuge in Canada, a process that took seven months with a temporary stay in Albania while awaiting approval from the Canadian government. During her time in Albania, she assumed the role of a team leader, continuing her dedication to assisting refugees. Upon her arrival in Canada, she not only successfully established herself but also took the initiative to register an organization with help of her friend Latifa Majidi. This organization, recognized for its leadership in women's issues, particularly within the context of Afghan refugees in Canada, reflects her ongoing commitment to fostering positive change. Her decision to persist in her advocacy for Afghan women in Canada exemplifies both resilience and leadership. Through her efforts, she contributes significantly to the well-being and empowerment of Afghan women, promoting their integration into Canadian society. Overall, her story

highlights a commendable dedication to humanitarian work and a steadfast commitment to making a meaningful impact on the lives of those in need.

<https://acwgc.ca/> (link to the organization that Robina and Latifa registered together.)

Latifa Majidi: Latifa Majidi is a seasoned leader with a proven track record in the realm of women's economic empowerment and development. Holding a master's degree in Public Administration, she stands as the founder and CEO of the ACWGC organization based in Calgary, Canada. Latifa's relocation to Canada in 2022 was prompted by the distressing events in Afghanistan following the Taliban takeover. Enduring a six-month sojourn in Greece while awaiting approval from the Canadian government, Latifa's commitment to securing a safe life for her family and herself remained unwavering. Upon her arrival in Canada, Latifa promptly immersed herself in humanitarian efforts, extending support to fellow refugees. Her initiatives encompassed diverse activities, ranging from imparting ESL (English as a Second Language) classes to women in need to establishing an organization tailored for the welfare of Afghan women residing in Canada. Latifa's dedication to fostering empowerment and community support underscores her unwavering commitment to positively impact the lives of those in need.



Mohamad Shafiq Hamdard: Mohamad Shafiq Hamdard is a prominent television personality renowned for offering insightful political commentary. A staunch critic of the Taliban, he previously held positions within the government and earned his master's degree from a prestigious university in Kabul. Unfortunately, many of his associates and friends fell victim to the Taliban's reprisals due to their outspoken opposition. In light of escalating threats to his safety even prior to the Taliban's takeover, Hamdard, driven by concerns for the well-being of his family, sought refuge in Albania. In April 2022, he made the courageous decision to relocate to Canada, embarking on a new chapter in his life. Upon arrival in Canada, Hamdard faced the challenge of navigating language barriers, which initially limited his career options. Despite his extensive background in office-based roles in Afghanistan, he adapted to his circumstances by choosing to work as an Uber driver. This shift in career trajectory has left him feeling disheartened and frustrated, as it starkly contrasts with the professional landscape he once thrived in. Hamdard's experience highlights the significant adjustments and sacrifices individuals make when forced to leave their homeland under perilous circumstances. Despite the challenges he faces, his resilience and determination to forge a new life in Canada are commendable, underscoring the realities that many displaced individuals encounter in pursuit of safety and stability.



Tajala Amiri Tajala Amiri embarked on a transformative journey at the age of 17, compelled by the necessity to ensure the safety of her parents. Born and raised in Afghanistan, her mother's prominent position in the government prompted the family to seek refuge abroad. After a six-month stay in Greece, during which their legal case was successfully approved, they relocated to Canada in 2022.

Despite the challenges of adapting to a new country, Tajala demonstrated resilience and commitment to her education. Upon enrolling in 11th grade at a Canadian high school, she quickly forged connections with her peers, many of whom now reside in various countries. Despite the physical distance, Tajala maintains strong bonds with her classmates, fostering a global network of friendships. Driven by a passion for medicine, Tajala is currently dedicated to her academic pursuits, aspiring to become a doctor. Her journey reflects not only personal growth but also a commitment to overcoming obstacles in pursuit of her dreams. Tajala's story is a testament to the strength of character and determination that propels individuals to overcome adversity and contribute positively to their new communities.



- **Conclusion**

In conclusion, refugees are individuals who have faced significant challenges and hardships in their home countries and have had to flee to seek safety and security. Canada is a welcoming and accepting country that has a long history of supporting and providing opportunities for refugees and migrants. The government and Canadian people have put in place policies and programs to support diversity, inclusion, and social welfare, which has helped many refugees integrate into Canadian society. Canada's commitment to humanitarianism and multiculturalism is a testament to its values and principles, and we must continue to raise awareness about the refugee situation and encourage Canadian youth to be welcoming and accepting of refugees.

